

Post-Operative Instructions: Dental Implants

The first 2 weeks after surgery are very important. Healing of the bone around the implants takes 3 to 6 months.

Diet

A soft, mild, and nutritionally balanced diet should be consumed for 2 to 4 days (or longer if necessary) after your surgery. You should chew on the opposite side of where the implant was placed for 2 weeks (if possible). As the tissue around the implant heals, you can return to your normal eating routine.

Swelling

Swelling from oral surgery is normal and reaches its maximum in 48 hours. Keeping the head elevated with 2 pillows when lying down can minimize facial swelling. Swelling can also be minimized by applying cold compresses to your face (30 minutes on, 30 minutes off) for the first 48 hours. After 48 hours, warm compresses will help reduce the swelling. These should be continued (30 minutes on, 30 minutes off) until the swelling has subsided.

Rinsing

Avoid rinsing the mouth for 24 hours after surgery. It may disturb the clot. If you have been given a prescription for chlorhexidine gluconate (Peridex), saturate a gauze pad and place over the surgical site for 1 minute, twice daily, for 7 to 10 days.

Brushing

If an implant protrudes through the gums, the metal must be kept clean. Use a cotton-tipped applicator or soft toothbrush and gently clean the implant and adjacent tooth surfaces. Be careful around the sutures.

Denture or Flipper

On the day of your surgery, you will be given specific instructions regarding when you should wear your denture or flipper. Possible options may include:

- Leave denture or flipper out of your mouth until you are instructed to wear it. It must be realigned before wearing it.
- Leave your denture or flipper in place for 48 hours.
- Wear your denture or flipper as instructed.

General precautions include:

- If any sores or swelling develop around or under your denture or flipper, leave them out of your mouth and call the office.
- If you cannot place your denture or flipper back in your mouth, leave them out and call the office.

Bleeding

If you experience heavy bleeding, it usually means that the gauze pads are being clenched between your teeth rather than pressing on the surgical area. Try repositioning fresh pads so that pressure is directly on the surgical

area, and your remaining teeth are kept apart slightly by the pad.

Pain

Most oral surgery procedures are accompanied by some degree of discomfort. There are many good strategies to get you through the process. Some form of pain reliever should be taken before the numbness goes away. Over-the-counter medications like ibuprofen (Advil or Motrin) or acetaminophen (Tylenol) are adequate if there are no allergies, they have been tolerated in the past, and they do not interfere with any other medications. For more involved procedures, a prescribed narcotic can be taken. The narcotic can also be alternated or taken in addition to ibuprofen if there are no allergies and it has been tolerated in the past. Taking your medications with food will decrease the chance of nausea. Remember, narcotic pain medications will impair your judgment and reflexes, so driving and operating heavy machinery is to be avoided.

Antibiotics

You may be prescribed antibiotics to prevent infections. If so, take all of the medication as directed. If you experience any adverse reactions, such as nausea, rash, or itching, discontinue the medication. A rash or itching may indicate an allergic reaction to a medication. Antihistamines (Benadryl) will usually counteract the hives, rash, and itching. Swelling of the lips or tongue or difficulty breathing may represent a more severe allergic reaction, and you should seek medical attention immediately.

Infection

Although antibiotics may be prescribed to prevent an infection, a wound infection may occur a day or several days after surgery. You may be suspicious of an infection if there is a sudden increase in swelling, throbbing pain, or a foul-tasting drainage from the wound. If you suspect infection, call the office as soon as possible.

Smoking and Alcohol

Tobacco and alcohol should be eliminated during the first 2 weeks after surgery.

Questions or concerns, call (225) 925-2118. After hours or on weekends, leave a message and someone will return your call shortly. For a medical emergency, including difficulty breathing, call 911 or go to your nearest emergency department.

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